Connecting Sikkim's vibrant traditions with national and international perspectives, SALF 2026 features luminaries such as Mamang Dai, William Dalrymple, Ranjit Hoskote, Chuden Kabimo and Nawaraj Parajuli, among others. Dai notes, "In my narratives, the land is akin to a protagonist. The physical environment is the source of the culture and beliefs of a community. Myths can lend context to a scene, but I use them more as reference to retrieve the original idea as composed in oral tradition, of what it means to be human."

THEMES LIKE CLIMATE CHANGE, BIODIVERSITY, IDENTITY AND MEMORY WILL FIND VOICE AT THE FESTIVAL

Addressing pressing themes, from climate change, biodiversity and Himalayan ecology to identity, memory and borderland experiences, the festival brings stories alive through panel discussions, music, performance and poetry concerts. Syed Shams Jawaid, festival producer and senior VP, Teamwork Arts, observes, "For us, the festival is not about putting these themes into separate boxes. It is about creating conversations between them and allowing different perspectives to meet. That is what makes a festival like this meaningful—when literature and the arts become a way of understanding the world around us and each other." ■

—Deepali Dhingra

The festival will take place at The Ridge Park, Gangtok, from Oct. 28-30



SERVICE OF STORY Announcing the fest are (L-R) Bhim Kumari Sharma, chairperson of the Culture Department; Syed Shams Jawaid, senior VP, Teamwork Arts; MLAs Delay Namgyal Barfungpa and Aditya Golay Tamang and Sonam Chopel Sherpa, chairman of the Student Welfare Board

Beaches

—as Inês Gonsalves' evocative photographs show







ON THE MARGINS The pictures portray regular Goans from 1994 to 2004, when the state was experiencing social and cultural transformation

Beyond its identity as one of India's most popular tourist destinations, Goa has a quieter side, of its people and their everyday lives. *Still/Goa: A Place in its People*, an exhibition presented by Sunaparanta Goa Centre for the Arts and the Consulate General of Portugal, offers a glimpse into this story through the photographs of Portuguese photographer Inês Gonsalves.

The exhibition brings together images taken between 1994 and 2004, capturing Goa when it was experiencing social and cultural transformation. Recalling her long association and love for the coastal state, Gonsalves says she first travelled to Goa in the 1990s to work on a book with Portuguese writer Catarina Portas, called *Goa: História de um Encontro*.

"I was taken in by the extraordinary generosity of the locals; the way doors opened, the way I was welcomed into homes and lives, often by people I had only just met. Those encounters became as important as the photographs themselves," she shares.

She continued to return to Goa, documenting its people, homes, rituals, streets and landscapes as she felt there was always something more to discover. "These photographs belong to a particular moment in time, but I also hope they convey something more timeless—that there is much more to Goa than beaches and landscapes," she adds. ■

—Deepa Natarajan Lobo

The exhibition is on till Oct. 24 at Sunaparanta Goa Centre for the Arts, Panaji